

Reflection Paper Whitney Text

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General Overview

The book about Spiritual Disciplines by Don Whitney helped me understand what it means to strive to enter into the gate, as Jesus says in Matthew. It is a difficult thing to enter into the kingdom of heaven, and we must exert all our energy and discipline in order to get closer to God.

One of the Bible verses Whitney uses is, “and for the holiness without which no one will see the Lord.” I think this is an apt verse that succinctly summarizes all the truths of spiritual disciplines. We must strive for the holiness with which we can see the Lord. If we don’t pray, read the Bible, or fast, we cannot draw near to God and see him. We will be distant and will suffer from illness.

From the book, I realized how important the disciplines are and renewed my desire to seek the Lord through methods and practices. Although it may seem like drudgery and Law, we must do all we can do enter into the gate.

Key Points

1) **Worship God**. I truly believe that worship of God is the beginning and end and middle of all spiritual disciplines. We are to worship God at all times. It is the telos and means. Why do we live? We want to worship God. And thus, we read the Bible and pray so that we can worship God. It’s a simple answer, but profound truth. We seek the Lord in prayer so that we can find answers to our life’s questions; but in the end, all that matters is giving God the glory and

glorifying him and honoring him. This is the end of man. I thought it was important to realize the true meaning of the disciplines.

2) **Methods.** I'm a freedom guy. I love freedom. I don't like putting myself in a box. I like being able to do whatever I want to do. But why put myself in a box? Because I am sinful and Law helps me acquire the goal faster and better. Methods help me to organize my life and seek the Lord in a more direct manner. I don't have all eternity to get my things straight - I need to direct my energies in an organized manner - and this is the method of methods.

I was surprised that I would even espouse methods, but I realized that I am in agreement with Whitney that methods are important.

3) **Drudgery.** I definitely believe the disciplines can be drudgery. But we start off in a place where there is no fruit, and slowly, God will add the vine and the fruit. We need to persevere. And this is not just prayer and fasting - it's life. When I don't have a job, when I'm taking class after class in seminary, when I'm waiting for someone to finish eating, I need to wait and be patient - and this is a spiritual discipline. I need to wait and wait and wait. I need to endure. I need to keep on going even when it is very boring. I need to endure to the end like a cockroach that cannot be smashed.

Personal Application

I thought that Spiritual Disciplines are something unnecessary when I first started reading, but I loved the way I came away from the book - going away with a sense of affirmation that I'm doing the right thing, and a better understanding of why I'm reading the Bible and praying.

The text affected my walk with the Lord by affirming that I am correctly praying and reading the Bible in the right motivation and vain. However, it challenged me to do so more methodically and more diligently. I actually don't aim to pray and make an effort to pray everyday. But this book tells me that I need to continue to methodically seek to serve the Lord and seek the Lord everyday.

The Bible has been something that I memorized but don't read anymore. The verses that I need come to mind, and the other parts of the Bible are necessary, but I need to study my seminary work.

What I realized after reading the book is that I need to read the Bible even as I study seminary work.

I seek the Lord in all that I do. And this is one of the aspects of the disciplines that I believe in the most. The disciplines that I must do is not just actions that I do at a particular time, but it's actually my daily life and it is what I do every moment of my life in relation to God.

What I realized is that the struggles that I have in my daily life as I brush my teeth and take a shower and eat my food and do my daily life is a crucifixion to God and it's a pleasing sacrifice to him. And by offering my life as a sacrifice, I am doing a spiritual discipline. Truly, the spiritual disciplines are not supposed to be a joyful thing that is so enjoyable that there is no pain in it. Spiritual disciplines are hard work and occasionally there is pain in doing so.

What I aim to do is to continue the spiritual discipline in my daily life and for it to guide me when I really need it when I'm in the ministry. What I believe is that the ministry is a fight it's warfare and that I need to go to prayer and to the Bible in order to win the battle.

Bibliography

Whitney, Donald S. *Spiritual Disciplines for the Christian Life*. Colorado Springs, CO:
NavPress, 1991.